

The Marine Corps, operating primarily in the northernmost part of South Vietnam (called I Corps), offered an alternative model for conducting the war. Marine initiatives to improve villagers' standard of living included providing school supplies for children, tools for tradesmen, and equipment such as rice threshers for villages; sharing farming expertise to improve livestock and crop yields; and building dams and digging wells to provide clean drinking water and irrigation. They also provided medical care and distributed emergency food and clothing. The Marine Corps in Vietnam integrated civic action into doctrine through the creation of the Combined Action Program (CAP). It began as an improvised solution to a manpower shortage in 1965, when a junior officer suggested using South Vietnamese militia units to augment Marine strength. Formalized in 1967, CAP facilitated the creation of Combined Action Platoons, which consisted of a Marine rifle squad (comprised of 13–15 men), a Navy corpsman, and a local militia unit. Participation was voluntary on both sides, and only CAP Marines with Vietnam combat experience were eligible. They received about 10 days of training in Vietnamese language and customs before they were sent to live in a village to forge bonds with local people.

“[We got] information about VC activities
whispered through windows in broken
English.”

MARINE CAPTAIN BING WEST, IN HIS MEMOIR, *THE VILLAGE*, 2003